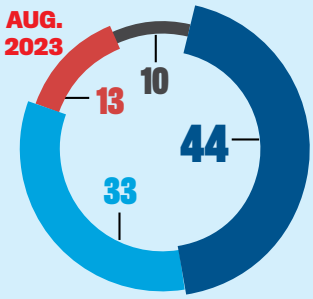
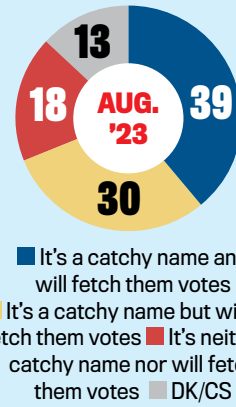
Q. Has your opinion of Rahul Gandhi changed after the Bharat Jodo Yatra?



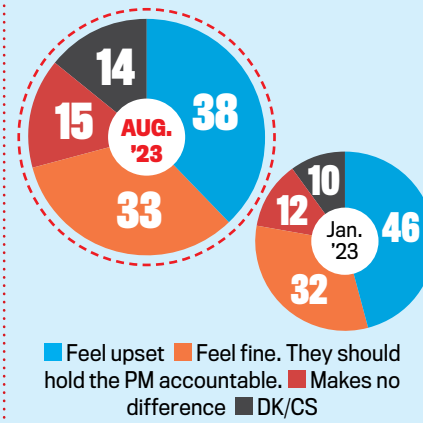
The Bharat Jodo Yatra has massively enhanced Rahul Gandhi's image among voters

Q. What do you think of the Opposition alliance calling itself INDIA?



The INDIA acronym for the Opposition combine has found support among the people

Q. How do you feel when Opposition leaders make personal attacks on PM Narendra Modi?



The share of voters upset at Modi being verbally attacked is down by 8 percentage points

All figures in % and rounded off; DK/CS (don't know/can't say)

leader to revive the Congress. This is the highest approval rating for Rahul in the past four years and a jump of 6 percentage points from January. Sachin Pilot, the second choice in the list, is backed by only 12 per cent of the respondents, down from 17 per cent in January. Former PM Manmohan Singh, a 90-year-old retired politician, continues to remain another trusted leader to revive the Congress, taking the third position. It shows the dearth of leaders with mass connect within the Congress. Rahul's sister Priyanka is a distant fourth with just 9 per cent of the respondents considering her a force to rejuvenate the party.

With Kharge as the chief negotiator, Rahul has been able to break the ice with new-found allies such as Mamata and Kejriwal, who often challenged the Congress leader's position as the face of an Opposition alliance. Victories in Karnataka and Himachal Pradesh have given Rahul more bargaining power in any discussion on the alliance. In contrast, the expansion plan of Mamata's TMC failed in states like Tripura, Meghalaya and Goa.

WITH KHARGE AS CHIEF NEGOTIATOR, RAHUL'S BEEN ABLE TO BREAK THE ICE WITH NEWFOUND ALLIES SUCH AS TMC AND AAP

Kejriwal's AAP met a similar fate in states like Gujarat and Goa though it got a massive boost after sweeping the Punjab assembly polls last year.

The contrast in the fortunes of the three political parties swung the public mood in Rahul's favour. In the MOTN poll, 24 per cent of the respondents, up from 13 per cent in January, say that Rahul is best-suited to lead the Opposition alliance among the current Opposition leaders. The support for Kejriwal sees a massive drop—from 24 per cent of the respondents backing him in January to 15 per cent now. Another 15 per cent repose faith in Mamata, though the percentage has dropped from 20 in January. What's even more encouraging for Rahul is that 52 per cent of the respondents rate his performance as an Opposition leader as good or outstanding. It seems his stand on the Hindenburg controversy around the Adani Group and Manipur violence have found resonance in the public psyche.

Rahul and the Congress are also displaying political acumen by avoiding playing big brother among the allies as the party announced that it was not interested in the prime ministerial position if an Opposition alliance came to power in 2024. The Congress's urgency to form a united Opposition front was reflected in its opposition to the controversial central ordinance that denied the Kejriwal government a final say in the transfer and postings of bureaucrats in the national capital. By doing this, the Congress top leadership went against its Delhi unit, which did not want to be seen on the same page as AAP. In response, Kejriwal instructed his party not to target the Congress.

The bonhomie among the alliance members was on full display during the two-day conference last month in